



FITNESSWISE

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Should coaches train along with their athletes?

Let's explore the **complex dynamics** of strength and conditioning (S&C) coaches engaging in player training sessions.

This highly intriguing and subjective topic often sparks debate among S&C coaches, generating a flurry of opinions from the fitness fraternity. There are a few key points to consider when evaluating its pros and cons.

There are high-profile coaches who don't fancy training with players and others who believe in it too strongly. On a personal level, I have had experience in both ways; therefore, I understand the real crux of the issue.

Initially, I used to train with players once or twice a week, either on the field or in the gym, but subsequently, I trained alone after the players' session was over.

To maintain a professional approach, I strictly focused on coaching during the week and then trained alone at the gym. This was for two reasons. First, intense training sessions during the week, be it in the gym or on the field, require my full attention to get the form and sequencing right.

Second, weekend training is more like a team-bonding exercise — either on the beach or through a game — that helps in understanding the players' psyche better.

An often ignored viewpoint is the notion of training along with players because coaches think there are only two possibilities — either the players think you're a dimwit for showing off or they see how ghastly poor you really are in executing movement patterns.

But this has nothing to do with knowledge or pleasing players, even when some players encourage you to demonstrate for their amusement.

Nevertheless, there are many points to ponder and many styles of coaching to choose from. What fits one coach need not fit another.

Here are some pointers that I think would be pertinent for many S&C coaches, although they may not be universally agreed upon.

Coaches are the least important athletes

It's necessary to understand that athletes are the first priority, and their performance is of prime importance. When athletes embark on strength and conditioning sessions, the duty of the coach is loud and clear — monitor them and give them feedback. If you fail to do so, you better not be there.

You're setting an example for your athletes

This can be a great opportunity to show your players what you expect of them and to set standards. Otherwise, your ignorance about the subject matter will be fully exposed, and they will not listen to you.

Players will observe you, and they'll model their behaviour on your own, consciously or not. If you behave in ways that you tell them not to, then don't be surprised when they ignore your lessons and pay attention to your bad examples instead.

Know your lifters

Many athletes admire coaches who continue their own training regimen, but don't mistake this for them wanting you to train alongside them. Make sure that your athletes are comfortable with you training